

IN CONTEXT

The Esterházy princes

The Esterházys were a Hungarian noble family, princes of the Holy Roman Empire, and among the largest landowners in Europe. They were loyal subjects of the Hapsburg emperors in Vienna, although often wealthier than the Hapsburgs themselves. Their Esterháza palace, begun in the 1760s, was on such a grand scale it was known as the “Hungarian Versailles.” It earned Haydn’s main patron, Prince Nikolaus Esterházy (1714–1790), the sobriquet “the Magnificent.” Prince Nikolaus II (1765–1833) was also a patron of music, commissioning Beethoven’s Mass in C in 1807, but the family’s fortunes never recovered from his profligacy and debauchery.



NIKOLAUS I, WEARING THE UNIFORM OF HIS HUNGARIAN INFANTRY REGIMENT

Franz Joseph Haydn was born in 1732 in the village of Rohrau, near the border between Austria and Hungary, the son of a